

Alex Rivera

Backend Engineer — distributed systems & developer tooling

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SUMMARY

Backend engineer with six years building high-throughput services. Comfortable owning a system end to end, from schema design through on-call. Recent focus on cutting latency and cost in data-heavy pipelines.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineer, Northwind Data — Austin, TX Mar 2022 – Present

- Rebuilt the ingestion pipeline around a partitioned queue, raising sustained throughput from 4k to 26k events/second.
- Cut p99 API latency by 63% by replacing per-request joins with a materialised read model.
- Led the migration of 40+ services to structured logging, reducing mean incident triage time from 22 to 8 minutes.
- Mentored three engineers; two were promoted within the year.

Software Engineer, Cobalt Systems — Remote Jul 2019 – Feb 2022

- Designed and shipped the public REST API now used by 1,200+ integration partners.
- Introduced contract testing across service boundaries, eliminating a recurring class of deploy-time regressions.
- Reduced cloud spend 18% by right-sizing workloads and consolidating idle clusters.

PROJECTS

queuelite — *Author* github.com/alexrivera/queuelite

A dependency-free job queue for Postgres, 2.1k stars.

- Exactly-once delivery via advisory locks and a visibility timeout, with no external broker.

EDUCATION

2015 – 2019 B.S. Computer Science at **University of Texas at Austin** (GPA 3.8/4.0)
Coursework: Distributed Systems, Databases, Compilers.

PUBLICATIONS

- A. Rivera, J. Okonkwo. *Backpressure Without Tears: Practical Flow Control in Event Pipelines*. USENIX SREcon Americas. 2024.

SKILLS

Languages	Python, Go, TypeScript, SQL
Infrastructure	PostgreSQL, Kafka, Redis, Kubernetes, Terraform
Practices	Distributed systems design, Observability, CI/CD, Incident response